

D840

# Teaching English Language Arts in Secondary Schools

Armored Drill

8 concepts · 12 items · 4 transfer items

**What this is.** Every concept in this course's public description, re-asked with more disguise than a practice test uses. Each stem carries facts that do not decide it. Every wrong answer is a named trap.

**Source.** Scope from the course's public description in the WGU Institutional Catalog (September 2026); items written from the field's standard body of knowledge. No WGU assessment item, course material or proprietary content is used or reproduced. Not affiliated with or endorsed by Western Governors University.

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# How to run it

Paper first. Pencil. One pass, no notes, a timer if you want the pressure.

1. **Before you read the options**, fill the strip under the item: the target word (what is actually being asked), and the one fact in the stem that decides it.
2. **Principle before arithmetic**. Name the rule, then compute.
3. **Camouflage**. Most of every stem does not matter. Ask: which single fact decides this?
4. **Inverse pairs are the bait**. If two options are opposites, one of them is the trap built for you.
5. **Mark sure, unsure or guess** honestly. Sure-and-wrong is the most valuable miss on the page — it is a wrong mental model.
6. **Absolutes** (always, never, guarantee) are usually wrong. And recognizing an answer is not the same as owning it.
7. Items with a **heavy black bar** on the left are **transfer items**: the same principle, reversed or solved for a different variable.
8. Stop at the STOP page. Then grade, fill the triage grid, and tally the traps you fell for. The biggest tally is what you drill next.

The strip, filled in, looks like this:

|                             |                                           |                        |                                  |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------|----------------------------------|
| <b>Target word</b><br>_____ | <b>The one fact that decides</b><br>_____ | <b>Answer</b><br>_____ | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ]<br>guess |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------|----------------------------------|

# Items

1.

During a whole-class discussion of a novel in a classroom with a new carpet, students raise hands and each shares an unrelated opinion, speaking only to the teacher. The discussion lasts 25 minutes. What is the best next step?

- A. Keep the format, since many students spoke.
- B. Teach norms and frames such as, I want to add to what \_\_\_ said, and, On page \_\_\_ it says \_\_\_.
- C. Replace discussion with a written quiz.
- D. Shorten the discussion to 10 minutes.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

2.

A teacher who coaches the speech team wants to assess listening during small-group discussions. She uses a clipboard she bought at a conference. Which evidence best shows listening?

- A. The teacher's clipboard is organized.
- B. A student paraphrases a peer's point accurately and then adds a related idea.
- C. A student stays quiet the whole time.
- D. A student speaks the most times.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

3. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A rubric row for speaking reads: Speaks well. Which revision makes it assessable?

- A. Always speaks perfectly.
- B. Listens quietly.
- C. Supports each claim with a specific detail from the text and speaks loudly enough for all to hear.
- D. Speaks very well.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

4.

A teacher who recently switched from teaching math has students copy dictionary definitions for ten words each Monday. The school uses a new vocabulary app. On Friday, students define the words correctly but never use them in writing. What should change?

- A. Give multiple exposures across the week: using the words in discussion, reading them in context, and writing with them.
- B. Keep the plan because students define words correctly.
- C. Assign twenty words instead of ten.
- D. Switch entirely to the app.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

5.

A ninth-grade class that just moved to a new wing scores 95% on comma-splice worksheets. The same students write comma splices throughout their essays. The worksheets come from a popular workbook. What should the teacher do?

- A. Teach the skill with sentences from students' own drafts and have them revise their essays right away.
- B. Grade only content and ignore conventions.
- C. Stop teaching grammar entirely.
- D. Assign more worksheets from the workbook.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

6. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

Which activity best reflects teaching grammar in context?

- A. Students study how an author uses dashes in a novel, then add a dash to a sentence in their own drafts.
- B. Students memorize a list of grammar rules.
- C. Students take a grammar test first.
- D. Students label parts of speech in 50 unrelated sentences.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

7.

A student who is on the honor roll finishes reading a short story silently and says, I read it, but I don't know what happened. The story is set in a mountain village. What should the teacher teach?

- A. Learning about mountain villages.
- B. Reading faster to finish sooner.
- C. Nothing; honor-roll students understand everything they read.
- D. Stopping at set points to check understanding and using fix-up strategies like rereading when confused.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

8.

After a lesson on identifying central ideas, a teacher who uses colorful sticky notes gives an exit ticket. Of 30 students, 18 identify the central idea correctly. Her mastery criterion is 80%. The lesson took 45 minutes. What should she do next?

- A. Extend the lesson to 90 minutes next time.
- B. Reteach only the 12 students in a small group while others move on.
- C. Move on, since more than half got it.
- D. Reteach the whole class with a new approach, since 60% is well below 80%.

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

9. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A class of 25 students has a mastery criterion of 80%. How many students must meet the target for the class to move on?

- A. 80
- B. 5
- C. 20
- D. 25

| Target word | The one fact that decides | Answer | [ ] sure [ ] unsure [ ] guess |
|-------------|---------------------------|--------|-------------------------------|
| _____       | _____                     | ___    |                               |

10.

During a formal class presentation, a student who recently moved from another region uses informal expressions and grammar from her home dialect. The presentation is about local history. How should the teacher respond?

- A. Ask her to present on her old region instead.
- B. Value the home dialect and teach how to shift to a formal register for formal presentations.
- C. Correct her publicly for using incorrect English.
- D. Allow any register in every situation.

|                             |                                           |                        |                                                                                                 |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Target word</b><br>_____ | <b>The one fact that decides</b><br>_____ | <b>Answer</b><br>_____ | <input type="checkbox"/> sure <input type="checkbox"/> unsure <input type="checkbox"/><br>guess |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

11. [TRANSFER — reversed stem / different variable]

A student uses formal language when texting friends and is teased for sounding stiff. What does this show?

- A. The student has a vocabulary problem.
- B. The friends' language is incorrect.
- C. Formal language is always best.
- D. The student needs to match register to setting, including informal ones.

|                             |                                           |                        |                                                                                                 |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Target word</b><br>_____ | <b>The one fact that decides</b><br>_____ | <b>Answer</b><br>_____ | <input type="checkbox"/> sure <input type="checkbox"/> unsure <input type="checkbox"/><br>guess |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

12.

After a unit, a teacher who recently repainted her classroom reviews data showing that 40% of students could not cite evidence in discussions. She drinks coffee during planning. Which goal is best for her action plan?

- A. Be a better discussion leader.
- B. Repaint the room a calmer color.
- C. By the end of next unit, 80% of students will cite text evidence in at least two discussion turns, tracked with a checklist.
- D. All students will always cite perfect evidence.

|                             |                                           |                        |                                                                                                 |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Target word</b><br>_____ | <b>The one fact that decides</b><br>_____ | <b>Answer</b><br>_____ | <input type="checkbox"/> sure <input type="checkbox"/> unsure <input type="checkbox"/><br>guess |
|-----------------------------|-------------------------------------------|------------------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|

# STOP

Answers and dissection follow. Finish every item and every strip first.

# Key and dissection

Struck-through text is the camouflage: facts that do not decide the item.

## 1. Answer B Concept 1

During a whole-class discussion of a novel ~~in a classroom with a new carpet~~, students raise hands and each shares an unrelated opinion, speaking only to the teacher. ~~The discussion lasts 25 minutes.~~ What is the best next step?

**Target word:** build accountable talk **Decides:** Students are not building on each other or using the text.

|   |                   |                                                   |
|---|-------------------|---------------------------------------------------|
| A | Absolute language | Participation alone is not productive discussion. |
| B | <b>Correct</b>    | Builds peer-to-peer, text-based talk.             |
| C | Dropped element   | Drops speaking and listening.                     |
| D | Camouflage        | Time is not the problem.                          |

## 2. Answer B Concept 2

A teacher ~~who coaches the speech team~~ wants to assess listening during small-group discussions. ~~She uses a clipboard she bought at a conference.~~ Which evidence best shows listening?

**Target word:** observable evidence of listening **Decides:** Listening shows in responses to others.

|   |                    |                                                       |
|---|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|
| A | Camouflage         | The tool is irrelevant.                               |
| B | <b>Correct</b>     | Shows the student understood and used another's idea. |
| C | Inverted operation | Silence does not show listening.                      |
| D | Adjacent category  | Measures speaking, not listening.                     |

## 3. Answer C Concept 2 · transfer

A rubric row for speaking reads: Speaks well. Which revision makes it assessable?

**Target word:** write an observable criterion **Decides:** Criteria must be observable.

|   |                   |                                                      |
|---|-------------------|------------------------------------------------------|
| A | Absolute language | Unrealistic and unmeasurable.                        |
| B | Confusion set     | Not a speaking criterion, and quiet is not evidence. |
| C | <b>Correct</b>    | Observable and specific.                             |
| D | Dropped element   | Still vague.                                         |

## 4. Answer A Concept 3

A teacher ~~who recently switched from teaching math~~ has students copy dictionary definitions for ten words each Monday. ~~The school uses a new vocabulary app.~~ On Friday, students define the words correctly but never use them in writing. What should change?

**Target word:** build depth **Decides:** One exposure through definitions is not enough.

|   |                    |                                        |
|---|--------------------|----------------------------------------|
| A | <b>Correct</b>     | Varied use builds deep word knowledge. |
| B | Dropped element    | Drops the goal of using the words.     |
| C | Inverted operation | More breadth, less depth.              |
| D | Camouflage         | The tool is not the issue.             |

## 5. Answer A Concept 4

A ninth-grade class ~~that just moved to a new wing~~ scores 95% on comma-splice worksheets. The same students write comma splices throughout their essays. ~~The worksheets come from a popular workbook.~~ What should the teacher do?

**Target word:** fix transfer failure **Decides:** Drills are not transferring.

|   |                   |                                           |
|---|-------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| A | <b>Correct</b>    | Grammar in context transfers to writing.  |
| B | Dropped element   | Drops a skill students need.              |
| C | Absolute language | Grammar still needs teaching, in context. |
| D | Camouflage        | More of the source is not the fix.        |

## 6. Answer A Concept 4 • transfer

Which activity best reflects teaching grammar in context?

**Target word:** choose the in-context practice **Decides:** Grammar applied to real reading and writing.

|   |                    |                                         |
|---|--------------------|-----------------------------------------|
| A | <b>Correct</b>     | Connects a model to students' writing.  |
| B | Adjacent category  | Knowledge without application.          |
| C | Confusion set      | Assessment, not instruction in context. |
| D | Inverted operation | Isolated drill.                         |

## 7. Answer D Concept 5

A student ~~who is on the honor roll~~ finishes reading a short story silently and says, I read it, but I don't know what happened. ~~The story is set in a mountain village.~~ What should the teacher teach?

**Target word:** comprehension monitoring **Decides:** The student did not notice meaning breaking down.

|   |                    |                                  |
|---|--------------------|----------------------------------|
| A | Camouflage         | Setting is not the issue.        |
| B | Inverted operation | Speed will not fix lost meaning. |
| C | Absolute language  | Any reader can lose meaning.     |
| D | <b>Correct</b>     | Builds monitoring and repair.    |

## 8. Answer D Concept 6

After a lesson on identifying central ideas, a teacher ~~who uses colorful sticky notes~~ gives an exit ticket. Of 30 students, 18 identify the central idea correctly. Her mastery criterion is 80%. ~~The lesson took 45 minutes.~~ What should she do next?

**Target word:** reteach decision **Decides:**  $18 / 30 = 60\%$ , below the 80% criterion.

|   |                   |                                                     |
|---|-------------------|-----------------------------------------------------|
| A | Camouflage        | Length does not decide the response to data.        |
| B | Adjacent category | Small-group reteaching fits when few miss, not 40%. |
| C | Absolute language | Half is not the criterion.                          |
| D | <b>Correct</b>    | Many students missed the target.                    |

### 9. Answer C Concept 6 · transfer

A class of 25 students has a mastery criterion of 80%. How many students must meet the target for the class to move on?

**Target word:** solve for number of students **Decides:**  $0.80 \times 25$ .

|   |                    |                                                 |
|---|--------------------|-------------------------------------------------|
| A | Wrong stem number  | The percent, not a count.                       |
| B | Inverted operation | That is how many can miss.                      |
| C | <b>Correct</b>     | $0.80 \times 25 = 20$ .                         |
| D | Dropped element    | Drops the criterion and requires every student. |

### 10. Answer B Concept 7

During a formal class presentation, a student who recently moved from another region uses informal expressions and grammar from her home dialect. ~~The presentation is about local history.~~ How should the teacher respond?

**Target word:** respond to dialect **Decides:** Dialects are rule-governed; register fits the setting.

|   |                    |                                                          |
|---|--------------------|----------------------------------------------------------|
| A | Camouflage         | The topic is irrelevant.                                 |
| B | <b>Correct</b>     | Code-switching respects language and builds flexibility. |
| C | Inverted operation | Treats a dialect as incorrect.                           |
| D | Absolute language  | Students need to choose registers for settings.          |

### 11. Answer D Concept 7 · transfer

A student uses formal language when texting friends and is teased for sounding stiff. What does this show?

**Target word:** register mismatch the other way **Decides:** Register must fit the setting in both directions.

|   |                    |                                            |
|---|--------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| A | Adjacent category  | The issue is register, not word knowledge. |
| B | Inverted operation | Informal registers are valid.              |
| C | Absolute language  | Not in every setting.                      |
| D | <b>Correct</b>     | Appropriate register depends on context.   |

### 12. Answer C Concept 8

After a unit, a teacher ~~who recently repainted her classroom~~ reviews data showing that 40% of students could not cite evidence in discussions. ~~She drinks coffee during planning.~~ Which goal is best for her action plan?

**Target word:** evidence-based goal **Decides:** Specific, measurable, tied to the data.

|   |                   |                                            |
|---|-------------------|--------------------------------------------|
| A | Dropped element   | Vague with no measure.                     |
| B | Camouflage        | Irrelevant.                                |
| C | <b>Correct</b>    | Specific, measurable, and tied to the gap. |
| D | Absolute language | Unrealistic.                               |

## Triage grid

Write each item number in the box it belongs to.

|                       | <b>Right</b>                                          | <b>Wrong</b>                                                                          |
|-----------------------|-------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| <b>Sure</b>           | Owled.                                                | <b>Concept inversion — top priority.</b> A wrong mental model; it survives rewording. |
| <b>Unsure / guess</b> | Recognition, not mastery. Re-drill with the transfer. | Not learned yet.                                                                      |

## Trap tally

For every miss, find the letter you chose in the key and tally its trap. The biggest number is the pattern to drill.

| <b>Trap</b>        | <b>What it does</b>                                          | <b>In this drill</b> | <b>Your misses</b> |
|--------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------|----------------------|--------------------|
| Dropped element    | Leaves out a required term or step.                          | 6                    |                    |
| Wrong stem number  | A figure copied from the prompt that is not the answer.      | 1                    |                    |
| Adjacent category  | The right idea in the wrong bucket.                          | 4                    |                    |
| Inverted operation | Direction flipped: add/subtract, cause/effect, higher/lower. | 7                    |                    |
| Absolute language  | Always, never, guarantee — where judgment applies.           | 8                    |                    |
| Confusion set      | Every option is real; the test is exact role-matching.       | 2                    |                    |
| Camouflage         | Answers a stem fact that was never the question.             | 8                    |                    |

## Anchor rows — the concept list

One row per concept: the rule to lock in, the trap that catches people, and the tell in the question that signals it.

| # | Concept                                 | Rule                                                                                                                                                               | Trap                                                                | Tell                                                                |
|---|-----------------------------------------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------|
| 1 | <b>Accountable talk</b>                 | Productive discussion requires students to build on each other's ideas, support claims with the text, and reason accurately; sentence frames and norms teach this. | Equating a lively discussion with a productive one.                 | Students talk past each other or only to the teacher.               |
| 2 | <b>Assessing speaking and listening</b> | Speaking and listening are assessed with observable criteria; listening is shown by what a student does with others' ideas, such as paraphrasing or responding.    | Assessing listening by whether a student was quiet.                 | A rubric or checklist for a discussion.                             |
| 3 | <b>Vocabulary depth</b>                 | Students learn words deeply through multiple, varied exposures and use in context, not a single definition.                                                        | Assuming copying a dictionary definition means the word is learned. | Students can define a word but not use it.                          |
| 4 | <b>Grammar in context</b>               | Grammar is best taught through students' own reading and writing, applied immediately, rather than in isolated drills.                                             | Believing worksheet drills transfer automatically to writing.       | Students ace grammar worksheets but make the same errors in essays. |
| 5 | <b>Comprehension monitoring</b>         | Skilled readers notice when meaning breaks down and use fix-up strategies such as rereading, reading on, or asking questions.                                      | Reading to the end without noticing confusion.                      | A student finishes a passage but cannot say what happened.          |
| 6 | <b>Using formative data to reteach</b>  | Compare the share of students meeting a target with a preset criterion; reteach whole-class when many miss, small-group when few miss.                             | Moving on because the lesson was taught.                            | Exit-ticket results and a mastery criterion.                        |
| 7 | <b>Register and language variation</b>  | All dialects are rule-governed; students learn to choose the register that fits the audience and setting (code-switching).                                         | Treating a home dialect as incorrect language.                      | A student's informal or dialect speech in a formal task.            |
| 8 | <b>Evidence-based action planning</b>   | A useful improvement plan sets a specific, measurable goal from student evidence, with actions and a way to check progress.                                        | Writing a vague goal such as be a better teacher.                   | A teacher reflecting on data to plan next steps.                    |

**Course scope (public description):** Teaching English Language Arts in Secondary Schools is designed to equip candidates with the skills and strategies necessary to effectively teach English Language Arts (ELA) to middle and high school students. The course begins with a focus on designing learning experiences that promote effective oral communication, ensuring students can express themselves clearly and confidently. It then delves into applying knowledge of language, guiding candidates in teaching the intricacies of language use, reading comprehension, and vocabulary acquisition. Next, the course emphasizes the implementation of instruction that assesses students' speaking and listening skills through various formative assessments, fostering active engagement and identifying areas for reteaching. Finally, candidates will create a comprehensive action plan for ELA instruction, reflecting on their instructional strategies and identifying opportunities for continuous improvement. Throughout the course,

candidates will learn to balance content rigor, scaffold learning, and employ evidence-based strategies to support diverse learners in developing critical language skills.